The power of these student unions linked to the political parties, receiving patronage from the political parties and manipulated by the political parties but also at times resisting the political parties, shows how important such student organizations have been to the political elite. Such political activism, though, does not necessarily strengthen democracy, as Welzel and Inglehart (2008) and Hoskins et al. (2012) have argued. Far from it; this activism reinforces the status quo, and is one of the factors that has led to a larger dissociation and depoliticization of the broader student body. Nelson traces the reactions of parents to the violence that their children were subject to on university campuses, many of whom (those who could afford to do so) placed their children in private universities. However, Nelson's work also highlights how both in public sector and especially in private sector universities the dominance of religiously linked student movements did not dissipate, though the attraction was more to organizations that were nonviolent and often apolitical. He traces the emergence and success of the Tablighi Jamaat, a largely Deobandi organization that does not believe in political action but associated itself with the larger Ummah; the Dawat-e-Islami, a largely Barelvi organization that is also apolitical though ideologically different from the Deobandis and linked to a transnational cause; and Hizb ut-Tahrir (HT) that predominantly targets the elite in private universities (2011). Under Musharraf especially, with his involvement in the global war on terror, and the HT declared an extremist organization in the United Kingdom, Musharraf also banned the HT in Pakistan, which far from disappearing went underground, like other campus-based societies before it. The danger of the nonpolitical, apolitical or transnational nature of these organizations is creating a further disconnect from local politics and the state, where political activism again is perceived as a problematic and corrupt phenomenon.

The lawyers' movement and PTI

On 9 March 2007, President General Pervez Musharraf suspended the chief justice of the Supreme Court, Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry. This engendered a peaceful resistance movement, largely termed 'the lawyers' movement'. The suspension of the CJ led Aitzaz Ahsan, the president of the Supreme Court Bar Association, to call on the Pakistani population to observe 'black flag week'. A rally was launched from Ahsan's residence in Lahore by the Lahore High Court Bar Association and the Lahore District Bar Association. During the next week